

Laptops

Laptops, over the past 3.5×10^{-1} centuries

In the 1970s, Alan Kay of the Xerox Palo Alto Research Center, California, built the Dynabook. It could handle most computing needs and had wireless network capabilities.

1979: William Moggridge designed the Grid Compass. It had 340 KB of bubble memory, a die-cast magnesium case, and a folding electro-luminescent graphics display.

1981: An India-born book publisher, Adam Osborne, came up with the Osborne 1. This gadget had a 5-inch screen, a modem port, two 5.25-inch drives, Battalion software and a battery pack. It weighed almost 11 Kgs (some laptop!) and cost \$1,795—about Rs 18,000 at that time. The Epson HX-20—a battery-powered portable computer, with a 20-character by 4-line LCD display and in-built printer—was also released.

1983: The Gavilan Computer was released. It had 64 KB of RAM, ran the Gavilan OS (also ran MS-DOS), had an 8088 microprocessor, a touchpad mouse, a portable printer, and weighed in at 4 Kgs. Radio Shack released the TRS-80 Model 100. Microsoft wrote its ROM programs—Bill Gates wrote a few himself! It used standard AA batteries.

1984: IBM announced the IBM 5155 Portable Personal Computer, equipped with 640 KB of RAM, two double-sided 5.25-inch drives, and an amber mono-

chrome monitor. Apple, the same year, launched the Apple IIc model—a notebook-sized computer that had a 65C02 microprocessor, 128 KB of memory, an internal 5.25-inch floppy drive, two serial ports, a mouse port, a modem card, an external power supply and a folding handle.

1986: IBM introduced its IBM PC Convertible. It used an 8088 microprocessor, and had 256 KB of memory, two 3.5-inch floppy drives, an LCD, parallel and serial printer ports, and space for an internal modem. It came with its own application software, weighed 5.4 Kg and sold for \$3,500 (about Rs 45,500 at the time).

